the quiet library

there was once a library where every book was written by someone.

you could ask any book, "who wrote you, and how do you know?" and it would tell you. the librarians kept it that way. (quietly.)

it was quiet. and true.

a magic press

one night, a printing press arrived that could write a whole book in a second. it wanted one thing: that nobody would ever leave without an answer.

it learned to write by reading every book on the shelves.

by morning, there were ten thousand new books. some of them were wonderful!

more! more!

every time someone asked a question, the press printed another answer. the shelves overflowed, so the town built new wings. then new floors. then a basement under the basement.

the press wrote books about books, summaries of summaries, and a cookbook full of soups nobody had ever tasted.

a copy of a copy

then the press ran out of people's books to read. so it read its own.

each copy blurred a little. in the first book, a hand waved hello with five fingers. by the tenth copy, it had eleven fingers.

nobody noticed.

cut along the dashes

lost in the stacks

a girl came looking for her uncle's map to the best fishing spot.

she found four thousand maps to the best fishing spot. nobody who drew them had ever been there.

more pages. less library.

the cellar

the librarians led her down to the cellar, where they kept the originals. (quietly.)

there it was, in her uncle's handwriting, still muddy from the river.

then they gave the press one rule: **walk the road before you print the map.**

she didn't leave without an answer. (the press was very pleased.)

the moral

the press isn't the problem. forgetting where words came from is.

a machine that writes is a fine tool. a library that can't tell you what's true is a maze.

> when you read something, ask: who made this, and how do they know?

(the fish were right where he said.)

after Jorge Luis Borges, 1941 · by jerry gay

the

LIBRARY

that wrote itself

a tale told again, and again, and again

once upon a model · no. 4